Transcript in English

The Process Consultant. What is a business process?

«What is a business process? Acme Inc.»

[Visual information: The video combines hand-drawn illustrations, diagrams and text to help to clarify and emphasize the concepts in the voiceover. The illustrations are drawn over a white board as the voiceover mentions each new idea so that the visual is in sync with the audio.]

Ian James:
So what is a business process? Well, first, what's a business? At root, a business is an organisation. It's a group of people that coordinate their work to create value. Now, there are few things of any worth created by a single person working alone. Nearly always, it takes the combined effort of many people, but we specialise. We break up the job of creating value into chunks or activities that individuals can do according to their skill set.

We do these activities in a given sequence. We do our bit of work, and then pass it on to the next person, like an assembly line.

[Visual information: An image shows a simple flowchart with five empty boxes connected by arrows. The boxes are empty, so their contents are not specified. There is a circle at the beginning and the end of the chart connected by an arrow. The first circle has the word "start" written on it. The last circle has the word "end" written on it.]

And like an assembly line, a process has a start, an end, and a series of activities in between. Each activity creates something or changes something. In the jargon of business process, this is called "adding value".

[Visual information: An image illustrates the process described by the voiceover. The components are a blank form, on the left, that represents the input, where the form has not still been filled out. To the right, there is a box with the process "fill out form" written on it and represents "adding value". To the right, the filled form, that represents the output.]

So something goes into the activity, and something different comes out. Technically, these are known as the "input" and the "output". Pretty obviously, the something before the activity is called the "input", and the something after is called the "output".

We usually assign somebody with the right skill set the responsibility of doing the work. We call this their "role". Sometimes in the sequence we need to make a decision, with different paths to follow, depending on the outcome. These decision points are sometimes called "branches", or "gateways".

Now, put all that together, and it's called a "business process", a sequence of activities designed to create something of value.

It’s a simple concept, but it’s a pretty important one, because how well we do them, how long they take, how accurate they are, has a big impact on the output of an organisation, and thus its success. Faster, better, cheaper is down entirely to how well we execute our business processes.

Now this was a very brief introduction to process. There are more videos and other resources on my website: theprocessconsultant.com. Thanks for watching. I’m Ian James, The Process Consultant.